

# Downloads for Designer

From design tips to fonts and stock photography, here is a collection of sites that deliver just that... and everything else in-between

Are you an aspiring page or graphics designer but lack the money to set up your own utility-rich studio? If so, you have company. There are many out there who hold the same dreams (small-time magazines included) for whom plunking down a few lakhs for the equipment and its upkeep is a major hurdle. Besides, finding skilled and talented personnel to get the job done right is another painstaking task. The Internet however can be a teaming resource for all those design elements you are seeking. Thousands across the world, all experts in their field of design, regularly contribute to the Web products replete with their diverse talents. Samples of art, photography and fonts are easily available both for commercial use or simply to add to your own collection. Some material can be obtained freely, while others need to be bought and sometimes licensed. We marched through a maze of design sites and have returned to offer you some guidelines that will help you utilise the Internet as a virtual design super-store.

## Typography rules

Sometimes, words can illustrate a point with greater emphasis than a picture. Whether it's a title, quote or just plain body text, you need the right typeset, one that perfectly matches up to the tone of the story. Of the many facets of design, it is perhaps easiest to get hold of free fonts. Your search for pretty character faces begins with [www.fontfreak.com](http://www.fontfreak.com), a site abounding with thousands of free PC and Mac fonts, dingbats and font control software. It's updated several times a week,

with freeware as well as shareware fonts, ensuring that you receive a fresh batch of originally crafted typefaces.

Fontsite.com has a polished look and substance apt for the type and graphics professional. Not only do they offer high-quality typefaces in TrueType and PostScript formats, but FontSite also features a series of informative articles ranging from choosing the right typeface to managing the life of a production artist.

For fonts that go against the grain, check out [www.acidfonts.com](http://www.acidfonts.com). You won't find any of the standard fare of Arial and Verdana. Each fortnight, Acidfonts keeps you posted on what's cool as far as fonts are concerned. They even have a section dedicated to the sci-fi genre. Going a step further, [www.abstractfonts.com](http://www.abstractfonts.com) offers its own share of unconventional characters neatly arranged in categories such as 3D, Cartoon, Celtic and more. Unlike other font sites, Abstract Fonts has an interac-

tive forum where users can help each other in searching for a particular typeset or helping identify the names of some of the more unfamiliar ones.

If you are scouting the Web for typefaces that have a conservative and professional touch, your best bet would be the International Typeface Corporation, or [www.itsfonts.com](http://www.itsfonts.com). In addition to their collection of 1,000 odd fonts, ITC keeps a staff of designers for custom font designing if that is what you're looking for. However, note that ITC Fonts doesn't offer much in terms of free stuff. Most of their products are sold through a wide variety of licensing options.

## Those nifty essentials—plugins and filters

To a designer, applications such as QuarkXPress, Adobe PageMaker and Photoshop are the enabling tools for their skills and creativity. But at some point, the standard fare of functions and fea-

tures tends to taper down the creative ability of a designer. Thankfully, there are hundreds of free (and otherwise) plugins and filters, which can add new facets to a program's functionality. From image filters to conversion utilities, these nifty add-ons often deliver real value to the application and its purpose.

Adobe Photoshop plugins are some of the most easily accessible of all design applications. Head towards [www.actionxchange.com](http://www.actionxchange.com). This is a unique community site where you can download and share several easy-to-install



A treasure trove of royalty-free fonts exists online